

Simplicial Topology

Labix

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Contents

1	Simplicies	3
1.1	Basic Definitions	3
1.2	Barycentric Subdivision	3
2	Simplicial Complexes	6
2.1	Basic Definition	6
2.2	Realizing a Simplicial Complex	7
2.3	Maps between Simplicial Complexes	7
2.4	Cubical Embeddings of Simplicial Complexes	8
3	Properties of Simplicial Complexes	9
3.1	The Face Vector of a Simplicial Complex	9
3.2	Neighbourly Complexes	9
3.3	Shellability	10
3.4	Vertex Decomposition	10
4	Operations on Simplicial Complexes	11
4.1	Barycentric Subdivision	11
4.2	Links and Stars	12
4.3	The Join of Simplicial Complexes	12
4.4	The Connected Sum of Simplicial Complexes	12
5	Algebraic Simplicial Complexes	13
5.1	Order Complexes	13
5.2	Matching Complexes	13
5.3	Flag Complexes	13
6	Realizing Simplicial Complexes in Euclidean Space	14
6.1	Geometric Realization	14
6.2	Properties of Geometric Realization	15
6.3	Simplicial Approximation	15
6.4	Triangulated Spaces	15
6.5	Piecewise Linear Maps	16
6.6	Combinatorial and Simplicial Spheres	16
7	Delta Complexes and Simplicial Homology	17
7.1	Delta Complexes	17
7.2	Delta Complex Structures	17
7.3	Simplicial Homology	18
7.4	Relation to Refinements	19
7.5	Simplicial Cohomology	19
7.6	The Alexander Dual	19

1 Simplicies

1.1 Basic Definitions

Definition 1.1.1 (Affinely Independent)

Let $n, m \in \mathbb{N}$. We say that a set of points $\{v_0, \dots, v_m\} \subset \mathbb{R}^n$ is affinely independent if $v_1 - v_0, \dots, v_n - v_0$ are linearly independent.

Definition 1.1.2 (n -Simplexes)

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Let $v_0, \dots, v_n \in \mathbb{R}^n$ be a set of affinely independent points. An n -simplex is the set of points

$$\Delta^n = \left\{ \sum_{k=0}^n t_k v_k \mid \sum_{k=0}^n t_k = 1 \text{ and } t_k \geq 0 \text{ for all } k = 0, \dots, n \right\}$$

We write $\Delta^n = [v_0, \dots, v_n]$ to indicate the spanning vectors. The standard n -simplex is just the n -simplex whose vertices are the standard basis vectors for $\mathbb{R}^{n+1}$.

Note that the vertices here are an ordered set so that an orientation is inherently defined. Realistically, the order of the vertices does not change the homology groups which we will define later.

Definition 1.1.3 (Properties of n -Simplexes)

- Let $\Delta^n = [v_0, \dots, v_n]$ be an n -simplex.
- The k th face of Δ^n is a the $n - 1$ simplex $\Delta_k^n = \Delta^n \cap \{x_k = 0\}$. We use $[v_0, \dots, \hat{v}_k, \dots, v_n]$ to indicate the k th $n - 1$ dimensional face
 - The boundary of Δ , written $\partial\Delta^n$ is the union of all its proper faces
 - The interior is defined to be $(\Delta^n)^\circ = \Delta^n \setminus \partial\Delta^n$

Definition 1.1.4 (The Vertex Set of a Simplex)

Let $S = [v_0, \dots, v_n] \subseteq \mathbb{R}^n$ be a simplex. Define the vertex set of the simplex to be

$$V(S) = \{v_0, \dots, v_n\}$$

It is easy to see that any face of an n -simplex is an $n - 1$ simplex in its own right.

Lemma 1.1.5 Any two k -simplexes where one in $\mathbb{R}^m$ and one in $\mathbb{R}^n$ are homeomorphic.

1.2 Barycentric Subdivision

Barycentric subdivisions is the main ingredient for proving one of the major results of singular homology. It is defined first through Δ -set, and then passed on to singular n -simplexes, which we will see in the next chapter.

Definition 1.2.1 (Barycenter) Let $v = [v_0, \dots, v_n]$ be an n -simplex. Define the barycenter of v to be the point

$$B(v) = \frac{1}{n+1} \sum_{i=0}^n v_i$$

In fact, we can find the barycenter inductively. Knowing the barycenter b_i on the i th face $[v_0, \dots, \hat{v}_i, \dots, v_n]$, let l_i be the line connecting b_i and v_i . Then b is the intersection of all these lines l_i .

Definition 1.2.2 (Barycentric Cone) Let v be an n -simplex. Let $w = [w_1, \dots, w_n] \subseteq v$ be an $(n - 1)$ -simplex in v . Define the barycentric cone of w to be the n -simplex

$$\mathcal{B}(w) = [B(v), w_1, \dots, w_n] \subset v$$

Intuitively, this means that given a face of Δ^n which is an $(n - 1)$ -simplex, its barycentric cone is the n -simplex constructed from the vertices of the face together with the barycenter.

Definition 1.2.3 (The Barycentric Map) Let v be an n -simplex. Define the barycentric map of v to be the map

$$\mathcal{B} : C_{n-1}(v) \rightarrow C_n(v)$$

defined on the basis by $\mathcal{B}([w_1, \dots, w_n]) = [B(v), w_1, \dots, w_n]$.

Definition 1.2.4 (Barycentric Subdivision) Let Δ^n be the standard n -simplex. Define inductively the barycentric subdivision

$$S^\Delta(\Delta^n) \in C_n(\Delta^n)$$

of Δ^n by the following recursive formula.

- When $n = 0$, $S^\Delta(\Delta^0) = \Delta^0$
- When $n > 0$, the barycentric subdivision of Δ^n is given by

$$S^\Delta(\Delta^n) = \sum_{i=0}^n (-1)^i \mathcal{B} S^\Delta(\partial_i \Delta^n)$$

To elicit a few examples, consider the case of $n = 1$. Then we have

$$\begin{aligned} S(\Delta^1) &= \mathcal{B} S(\partial \Delta^1) \\ &= \mathcal{B} S(\partial_0 \Delta^1) - \mathcal{B} S(\partial_1 \Delta^1) \\ &= \mathcal{B}[v_1] - \mathcal{B}[v_0] \\ &= [b, v_1] - [b, v_0] \end{aligned}$$

where $b = \frac{1}{2}(v_0 + v_1)$. Intuitively, we are breaking up the n -simplex Δ^n into tiny pieces of n -simplexes using the center of mass of each subsimplex in Δ^n .

Lemma 1.2.5 Let $\sigma = [w_1, \dots, w_n] \subseteq \Delta^n$ be an $(n-1)$ -simplex. Then the following are true.

- $\partial(\mathcal{B}(\sigma)) + \mathcal{B}(\partial\sigma) = \sigma$
- $\partial S(\Delta^n) = S(\partial \Delta^n)$

Proof We have that

$$\begin{aligned} \partial \mathcal{B}[w_1, \dots, w_n] &= \partial[b, w_1, \dots, w_n] \\ &= \sum_{i=0}^n (-1)^i \partial_i [b, w_1, \dots, w_n] \\ &= [w_1, \dots, w_n] - \mathcal{B}(\partial[w_1, \dots, w_n]) \end{aligned}$$

And thus the first identity is satisfied.

We prove the second item inductively. When $n = 0$, we have 0 on both sides. When $n > 0$, we have

$$\begin{aligned} \partial S \Delta^n &= \partial \mathcal{B}(S(\partial \Delta^n)) \\ &= \text{id}(S \partial \Delta^n) - \mathcal{B}(\partial(S \partial \Delta^n)) && \text{(First Identity)} \\ &= S \partial \Delta^n - \mathcal{B}(S \partial^2 \Delta^n) && \text{(Induction)} \\ &= S \partial \Delta^n \end{aligned}$$

■

Lemma 1.2.6 Let $v = [v_0, \dots, v_n]$ be a simplex. Let $[w_0, \dots, w_n]$ be a component in the barycentric subdivision of v . Then we have

$$\text{diam}([w_0, \dots, w_n]) \leq \frac{n}{n+1} \text{diam}([v_0, \dots, v_n])$$

Proof If $n = 0$, then the claim is true since $[w_0] = [v_0]$ has diameter 0. Assume that $n > 0$. We first prove the following subclaim: For every $x \in [x_0, \dots, x_n]$ an n -simplex, its maximum distance to points in the simplex is attained at a vertex x_i . Indeed if $y \in [x_0, \dots, x_n]$ with $\|x - y\|$ maximal, then we can write $y = \sum_{i=1}^n t_i x_i$ with $\sum_{i=1}^n t_i = 1$ and $t_i \geq 0$. Then we have that

$$\begin{aligned} \|x - y\| &= \left\| x - \sum_{i=1}^n t_i x_i \right\| \\ &= \left\| \sum_{i=1}^n t_i (x - x_i) \right\| \\ &\leq \sum_{i=1}^n t_i \|x - x_i\| \\ &\leq \max \|x - x_i\| \end{aligned}$$

with equality if y is one of the vertices with $\|x - x_i\|$ being maximal. By applying the above twice, we have that the diameter of $[w_0, \dots, w_n]$ is the length of the longest edge $[x, y]$ in $[w_0, \dots, w_n]$. Now there are two cases.

Case 1: None of x, y is the barycenter b of $[w_0, \dots, w_n]$. Then they must be the vertices of a simplex in the barycentric subdivision of one of the faces $[v_0, \dots, \hat{v}_i, \dots, v_n]$. By induction, we have that

$$\begin{aligned} \text{diam}([w_0, \dots, w_n]) &= \|x - y\| \\ &\leq \frac{n-1}{n} \text{diam}([v_0, \dots, \hat{v}_i, \dots, v_n]) \\ &\leq \frac{n}{n+1} \text{diam}([v_0, \dots, v_n]) \end{aligned}$$

and so we are done.

Case 2: Without loss of generality, $x = b$.

Then y lies on some face of $[v_0, \dots, v_n]$ and the claim above implies that we can take $y = v_i$ for some vertex v_i of that face. Let b_i be the barycenter of $[v_0, \dots, \hat{v}_i, \dots, v_n]$. Then we have that the barycenter of $[v_0, \dots, v_n]$ is

$$b = \frac{1}{n+1} \sum_{j=1}^n v_j = \frac{1}{n+1} v_i + \frac{n}{n+1} b_i$$

We thus have that

$$\begin{aligned} \text{diam}([w_0, \dots, w_n]) &= \|v_i - b\| \\ &\leq \frac{n}{n+1} \|v_i - b_i\| \\ &\leq \frac{n}{n+1} \text{diam}([v_0, \dots, v_n]) \end{aligned}$$

and so we conclude. ■

2 Simplicial Complexes

2.1 Basic Definition

Definition 2.1.1 (Abstract Simplicial Complex)

Let S be a set. We say that S is a simplicial complex if for all $\sigma \in S$ and $\tau \subseteq \sigma$, we have $\tau \in S$. Elements of S are called faces.

Example 2.1.2

The following are simplicial complexes.

- The n -polygon $\{\{i, i+1\} \mid 1 \leq i \leq n-1\} \cup \{\{1, n\}\}$.
- The n -simplex $\mathcal{P}(\{1, \dots, n+1\})$.
- The boundary of the n -simplex $\mathcal{P}(\{1, \dots, n+1\}) \setminus \{1, \dots, n+1\}$.

Example 2.1.3

The set $S = \mathcal{P}(\{1, 2, 3\}) \cup \mathcal{P}(\{1, 3, 4\}) \cup \mathcal{P}(\{2, 4\})$ is an abstract simplicial complex.

Definition 2.1.4 (The Boundary of a Face)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Let $\sigma \in \mathcal{K}$. Define the boundary of σ by

$$\partial\sigma = \{\tau \in \mathcal{K} \mid \tau \subseteq \sigma\}$$

Lemma 2.1.5

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Let $\sigma \in \mathcal{K}$. Then $\partial\sigma$ is a simplicial complex.

Definition 2.1.6 (Dimension)

Let S be a simplicial complex.

- Let $\sigma \in S$. Define the dimension of σ to be

$$\dim(\sigma) = |\sigma| - 1$$

- Define the dimension of S to be

$$\dim(S) = \max\{\dim(\sigma) \mid \sigma \in S\}$$

Definition 2.1.7 (The Skeleton of a Simplicial Complex)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Define the i th skeleton of $\mathcal{K}$ by

$$\text{sk}_i \mathcal{K} = \{\sigma \in \mathcal{K} \mid \dim(\sigma) \leq i\}$$

Definition 2.1.8 (Vertices and Maximal Faces)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex.

- A vertex of $\mathcal{K}$ is a simplex in $\mathcal{K}$ of dimension 0. Denote the set of vertices of $\mathcal{K}$ by $V(\mathcal{K})$.
- A maximal face of $\mathcal{K}$ is a simplex σ such that if $\sigma \subseteq \tau$, then $\sigma = \tau$.

Definition 2.1.9 (Pure Dimensional Complexes)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. We say that $\mathcal{K}$ is pure dimensional if all maximal faces of $\mathcal{K}$ have the same dimension.

Lemma 2.1.10

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Then we have

$$V(\mathcal{K}) = \text{sk}_0(\mathcal{K}) = \bigcup_{\sigma \in \mathcal{K}} \sigma$$

We mostly consider the case where $V(S)$ is finite. In this case, we may replace the underlying set by $\{1, \dots, n\}$ for a suitable $n \in \mathbb{N}$.

Definition 2.1.11 (Missing Faces)

Let S be a simplicial complex. Let $\sigma \subseteq V(S)$. We say that σ is a missing face of S if the following are true.

- $\sigma \notin S$.
- For all $\tau \subseteq \sigma$, we have $\tau \in S$.

Denote the set of all missing faces of S by

$$\text{MF}(S) = \{\sigma \subseteq V(S) \mid \sigma \text{ is a missing face}\}$$

Definition 2.1.12 (Refinements)

Let $\mathcal{K}, \mathcal{L}$ be simplicial complexes. We say that $\mathcal{L}$ is a refinement of $\mathcal{K}$ if for all $\tau \in \mathcal{L}$, there exists $\sigma \in \mathcal{K}$ such that $\tau \subseteq \sigma$.

2.2 Realizing a Simplicial Complex

Definition 2.2.1 (Geometric Simplicial Complexes)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a set of simplexes. We say that $\mathcal{K}$ is a geometric simplicial complex if the following are true.

- For any $S \in \mathcal{K}$, every face $\partial_k S$ of S lies in $\mathcal{K}$.
- If S_1 and S_2 are two simplexes in $\mathcal{K}$, then either $S_1 \cap S_2$ is empty or $S_1 \cap S_2$ is a common face of both S_1 and S_2 .

Definition 2.2.2 (Associated Abstract Simplicial Complex)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a geometric simplicial complex. Define the associated abstract simplicial complex $A(\mathcal{K}) \subseteq \mathcal{P}(V(\mathcal{K}))$ as follows: For each simplex $\Delta \in \mathcal{K}$, we have $V(\Delta) \subseteq A(\mathcal{K})$.

Lemma 2.2.3

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Then $A(\mathcal{K})$ is an abstract simplicial complex.

2.3 Maps between Simplicial Complexes

Definition 2.3.1 (Simplicial Maps)

Let S, T be simplicial complexes. Let $f : V(S) \rightarrow V(T)$ be a function. We say that f is a simplicial map if for each $\sigma \in S$, we have $f(\sigma) \in T$.

Lemma 2.3.2

Let S, T, U be simplicial complexes. Let $f : V(S) \rightarrow V(T)$ and $g : V(T) \rightarrow V(U)$ be simplicial maps. Then $g \circ f$ is a simplicial map.

Example 2.3.3

If $\mathcal{L}$ is a refinement of $\mathcal{K}$, then there is a map $\mathcal{L} \rightarrow \mathcal{K}$ sending $\tau \in \mathcal{L}$ to the simplex $\sigma \in \mathcal{K}$ such that $\tau \subseteq \sigma$.

Definition 2.3.4 (Isomorphism of Simplicial Complexes)

Let S, T be simplicial complexes. Let $f : V(S) \rightarrow V(T)$ be a function. We say that f is an isomorphism if there exists a simplicial map $g : V(T) \rightarrow V(S)$ such that

$$g \circ f = \text{id}_{V(S)} \quad \text{and} \quad f \circ g = \text{id}_{V(T)}$$

2.4 Cubical Embeddings of Simplicial Complexes

Definition 2.4.1 (The Faces of the n -Cube)

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}^+$. Let $J \subseteq I \subseteq \{1, \dots, n\}$. Define the faces of I^n by

$$C_{J \subseteq I} = \{(x_1, \dots, x_n) \in I^n \mid x_i = 0 \text{ for } i \in J, x_i = 1 \text{ for } i \notin J\}$$

Definition 2.4.2 (The Cubical Embedding)

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Define the cubical embedding $i_c : |\Delta^n| \rightarrow [0, 1]^{n+1}$ as follows.

1. For $1 \leq k \leq n$, the barycenter of the k -dimensional face $B([e_{i_1}, \dots, e_{i_k}])$ is sent to $(u_1, \dots, u_{n+1}) \in [0, 1]^{n+1}$ where $u_j = 0$ if $j \in \{i_1, \dots, i_k\}$ and $u_j = 1$ otherwise.
2. Extend this into a piecewise linear embedding $i_c : |\Delta^n| \rightarrow [0, 1]^{n+1}$ as follows. For each simplex $[p_1, \dots, p_l]$ in the barycentric subdivision of Δ^n , $[i_c(p_1), \dots, i_c(p_l)]$ lies on a face of $[0, 1]^{n+1}$. Hence there exists a simplicial map sending $[p_1, \dots, p_l]$ to $[i_c(p_1), \dots, i_c(p_l)]$.

Lemma 2.4.3

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Then $\partial[0, 1]^n$ is a simplicial complex.

Definition 2.4.4 (Cubical Embeddings of Abstract Simplicial Complexes)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be an abstract simplicial complex. Define the cubical embedding of $\mathcal{K}$ to be the subspace

$$\text{cc}(\mathcal{K}) = i_c(|\mathcal{K}|)$$

3 Properties of Simplicial Complexes

3.1 The Face Vector of a Simplicial Complex

Definition 3.1.1 (The Face Vector)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be an abstract simplicial complex. Define the face vector $(f_0, \dots, f_{\dim(\mathcal{K})})$ of S by the formula

$$f_i = \text{The number of } i\text{-dimensional faces of } \mathcal{K}$$

for $0 \leq i \leq \dim(\mathcal{K})$. By convention, we set $f_{-1} = 1$.

Example 3.1.2

The following are true.

- The face vector of the n -polygon is given by (n, n) .
- The face vector of the n -simplex is given by $f_i = \binom{n+1}{i+1}$ for $0 \leq i \leq n$.
- The face vector of the boundary of the n -simplex is given by $f_i = \binom{n+1}{i+1}$ for $0 \leq i \leq n-1$.

Definition 3.1.3 (The h -Vector)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be an abstract simplicial complex. Let $(f_0, \dots, f_{\dim(\mathcal{K})})$ be the face vector of S . Define the h -vector $(h_0, \dots, h_{\dim(\mathcal{K})})$ of S by the formula

$$h_i = \sum_{k=0}^i (-1)^{i-k} \binom{n+1-k}{i-k} f_{k-1}$$

for $0 \leq i \leq \dim(\mathcal{K}) + 1$.

Example 3.1.4

The following are true.

- The h -vector of the n -polygon is given by $(1, -n^2, n(3-n)/2)$.
- The h -vector of the n -simplex is given by

$$h_i = \sum_{k=0}^i (-1)^{i-k} \binom{n+1}{i} \cdot (i-1) \cdots (i-k+1)$$

Lemma 3.1.5

Let S be an abstract simplicial complex on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. Let $(f_0, \dots, f_n)$ be the face vector of S . Let $(h_0, \dots, h_n)$ be the h -vector of S . Then the following are true.

- We have

$$\sum_{k=0}^{n+1} f_{k-1} (t-1)^{d-k} = \sum_{j=0}^{n+1} h_j t^{n+1-j}$$

for variable t .

- For $0 \leq i \leq n$, we have

$$f_i = \sum_{k=0}^{i+1} \binom{n+1}{i+1-k} h_k$$

3.2 Neighbourly Complexes

Definition 3.2.1 (k -Neighbourly Complexes)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. We say that $\mathcal{K}$ is k -neighbourly if for any $S \subseteq V(\mathcal{K})$ such that $|S| \leq k$, we have $S \in \mathcal{K}$.

Definition 3.2.2 (Neighbourly Complexes)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. We say that $\mathcal{K}$ is a neighbourly complex if $\mathcal{K}$ is $\lfloor \dim(\mathcal{K})/2 \rfloor$ -neighbourly.

Example 3.2.3

The following are true.

- Every simplicial complex is 1-neighbourly.
- Δ^n is $(n+1)$ -neighbourly.
- $\partial\Delta^n$ is n -neighbourly.

3.3 Shellability

3.4 Vertex Decomposition

4 Operations on Simplicial Complexes

4.1 Barycentric Subdivision

Recall that there is a notion of barycentric subdivision for simplicies. The definition easily extends to simplicial complexes, but not obvious for abstract simplicial complexes.

Definition 4.1.1 (Barycentric Subdivision)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Define the barycentric subdivision of $\mathcal{K}$ to be the abstract simplicial complex

$$\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K}) = \bigcup_{k=0}^{\infty} \{ \{v_0, \dots, v_k\} \subseteq \mathcal{P}(\mathcal{K}) \setminus \{\emptyset\} \mid v_0 \subset \dots \subset v_k \}$$

The vertex set of $\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})$ is $\mathcal{K}$.

The idea is to add vertex for each simplex in the simplicial complex so that the underlying set of the barycentric subdivision is $\mathcal{K}$. Since $\mathcal{K}$ is a subset of $\mathcal{P}(\mathcal{K})$, elements of $\mathcal{K}$ are partially ordered by inclusion, each inclusion with the geometric meaning of faces of the simplex.

Lemma 4.1.2

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Then the following are true.

- $\dim(\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})) = \dim(\mathcal{K})$.
- $\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})$ is a refinement of $\mathcal{K}$.

Proposition 4.1.3

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Then the following are true.

- For $0 \leq i \leq \dim(\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K}))$, the face vector for $\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})$ is given by

$$f_i(\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})) = \sum_{j=i}^{\dim(\mathcal{K})} b_{ij} f_j(\mathcal{K})$$

where

$$b_{ij} = \sum_{k=0}^i (-1)^k \binom{i+1}{k} (i-k+1)^{j+1}$$

- The matrix $(b_{ij}) \in M_{\dim(\mathcal{K})+1}(\mathbb{Z})$ is upper triangular and invertible.
- The face vector for $\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})$ is given by matrix multiplication:

$$f(\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})) = (b_{ij}) f(\mathcal{K})$$

Proposition 4.1.4

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Then the following are true.

- For $0 \leq i \leq \dim(\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K}))$, the face vector for $\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})$ is given by

$$h_i(\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})) = \sum_{j=0}^{\dim(\mathcal{K})+1} d_{ij} h_j(\mathcal{K})$$

where

$$d_{ij} = \sum_{k=0}^i (-1)^k \binom{\dim(\mathcal{K})+2}{k} (i-k)^j (i-k+1)^{\dim(\mathcal{K})+1-j}$$

- The matrix $(d_{ij}) \in M_{\dim(\mathcal{K})+2}(\mathbb{Z})$ is invertible.
- The h -vector for $\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})$ is given by matrix multiplication:

$$h(\text{Bd}(\mathcal{K})) = (d_{ij}) h(\mathcal{K})$$

4.2 Links and Stars

Definition 4.2.1 (The Link of a Face)

Let S be a simplicial complex. Let $\sigma \in S$. Define the link of σ to be

$$\text{lk}(\sigma) = \{\tau \in S \mid \sigma \cup \tau \in S \text{ and } \sigma \cap \tau = \emptyset\}$$

Definition 4.2.2 (The Star of a Face)

Let S be a simplicial complex. Let $\sigma \in S$. Define the star of σ to be

$$\text{st}(\sigma) = \{\tau \in S \mid \sigma \cup \tau \in S\}$$

Define the boundary of the star of σ to be

$$\partial \text{st}(\sigma) = \{\tau \in S \mid \sigma \cup \tau \in S \text{ and } \sigma \not\subseteq \tau\}$$

Lemma 4.2.3

Let S be a simplicial complex. Let $p \in V(S)$. Then we have

$$\text{lk}(p) = \partial \text{st}(p)$$

4.3 The Join of Simplicial Complexes

Definition 4.3.1 (The Join of Two Simplicial Complexes)

Let $\mathcal{K}_1, \mathcal{K}_2$ be simplicial complexes. Define the join of $\mathcal{K}_1$ and $\mathcal{K}_2$ to be

$$\mathcal{K}_1 * \mathcal{K}_2 = \{I_1 \amalg I_2 \mid I_1 \in \mathcal{K}_1, I_2 \in \mathcal{K}_2\}$$

Example 4.3.2

We have $\Delta^n * \Delta^m = \Delta^{n+m-1}$.

4.4 The Connected Sum of Simplicial Complexes

5 Algebraic Simplicial Complexes

5.1 Order Complexes

5.2 Matching Complexes

5.3 Flag Complexes

Definition 5.3.1 (Flag Complexes)

Let S be a simplicial complex. We say that S is a flag complex if for any $T \subseteq V(S)$ such that $\{v, w\} \in S$ for any $v, w \in T$, then $T \in S$.

6 Realizing Simplicial Complexes in Euclidean Space

6.1 Geometric Realization

Definition 6.1.1 (Geometric Realization with Respect to Function)

Let S be an abstract simplicial complex. Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Let $\phi : V(S) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ be a function. Define the geometric realization of S with respect to ϕ to be the space

$$|S|_\phi = \bigcup_{\sigma \in S} [\phi(s) \mid s \in \sigma]$$

Definition 6.1.2 (Affine Embedding)

Let S be an abstract simplicial complex. Let $\phi : V(S) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ be a function. We say that $|S|_\phi$ is an affine embedding if ϕ is injective.

Proposition 6.1.3

Let S be an abstract simplicial complex. Let $\phi : V(S) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ and $\psi : V(S) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ be affine embeddings. Then $|S|_\phi$ and $|S|_\psi$ are homeomorphic.

Since any two affine embeddings give homeomorphic geometric realizations, we often drop the underlying injective function and assume that a choice has been chosen.

Definition 6.1.4 (Geometric Realization of a Simplicial Map)

Let S, T be simplicial complexes. Let $\phi_1 : V(S) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^n$ and $\phi_2 : V(T) \rightarrow \mathbb{R}^m$ be affine embeddings. Let $f : S \rightarrow T$ be a simplicial map. Define the geometric realization of f to be the function

$$|f| : |S|_{\phi_1} \rightarrow |T|_{\phi_2}$$

given as follow. For each $x \in |S|$, there exists $\lambda_v \in \mathbb{R}$ such that $x = \sum_{v \in T_1} \lambda_v \phi_1(v)$ and $\sum_{v \in V(S)} \lambda_v = 1$. Then define

$$|f|(x) = \sum_{v \in V(S)} \lambda_v \psi(f(v))$$

Proposition 6.1.5

Let S_1, S_2 be simplicial complexes. Let $f : S \rightarrow T$ be a simplicial map. Then the following are true.

- Let $\sigma \in S$. Then we have

$$|f|(|\sigma|) = |f(\sigma)|$$

- Let $\sigma \in S$. Then $|f|_{|\sigma|}$ is affine linear.

Lemma 6.1.6

Let S, T, U be simplicial complexes. Let $f : S \rightarrow T, g : T \rightarrow U$ be simplicial maps. Then we have

$$|g \circ f| = |g| \circ |f|$$

Thus geometric realization is a functor from a pair (S, ϕ) where S is a simplicial complex on some set T and ϕ is an affine embedding, to its geometric realization with respect to the embedding.

Definition 6.1.7 (Standard Geometric Realization of Abstract Simplicial Complexes)

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}^+$. Let S be an abstract simplicial complex on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. Define the standard geometric realization of S to be the space

$$|S| = \bigcup_{I \in S} \Delta^I$$

where Δ^I is the $|I|$ -simplex with vertices e_i for $i \in I$.

By definition, the geometric realization $|S|$ is a subcomplex of the standard n -simplex $[e_1, \dots, e_{n+1}] \subseteq \mathbb{R}^{n+1}$.

Example 6.1.8

Let $n \in \mathbb{N}$. Consider the set $S = \mathcal{P}(\{1, \dots, n+1\})$. Then $|S|$ is the standard n -simplex.

6.2 Properties of Geometric Realization

Lemma 6.2.1

Let S be a simplicial complex. Then $|S|$ and $|\text{Bd}(S)|$ are homeomorphic.

Lemma 6.2.2

Let S be a simplicial complex. Let $p \in V(S)$. Then we have

$$|\text{st}(p)| = \bigcup_{F \in S, p \in F} |F|$$

Lemma 6.2.3

Let $\mathcal{K}_1, \mathcal{K}_2$ be simplicial complexes. Then we have

$$|\mathcal{K}_1 * \mathcal{K}_2| = |\mathcal{K}_1| * |\mathcal{K}_2|$$

TBR (cones and suspensions are not yet introduced).

Corollary 6.2.4

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex. Then the following are true.

- $|\Delta^0 * \mathcal{K}| = C|\mathcal{K}|$ (the cone of the space).
- $|\partial \Delta^1 * \mathcal{K}| = \Sigma|\mathcal{K}|$.

6.3 Simplicial Approximation

Definition 6.3.1 (Simplicial Approximations)

Let S, T be simplicial complexes. Let $f : |S| \rightarrow |T|$ be a continuous map. A simplicial approximation of f is a simplicial map $F : V(S) \rightarrow V(T)$ such that $|F|$ is homotopic to f .

Theorem 6.3.2 (The Simplicial Approximation Theorem)

Let S, T be simplicial complexes. Let $f : |S| \rightarrow |T|$ be a continuous map. Then there exists $n \in \mathbb{N}^+$ and a simplicial approximation $F : \text{Bd}^n(S) \rightarrow T$ of f .

Proposition 6.3.3

Let X be a CW complex. Then there exists a simplicial complex S such that $|S|$ is homotopic to X .

6.4 Triangulated Spaces

Definition 6.4.1 (Triangulated Spaces)

Let X be a space. We say that X is triangulated if there is a simplicial complex K such that $|K| \cong X$.

Hauptvermutung: If $\mathcal{K}$ and $\mathcal{L}$ are simplicial complexes such that $|\mathcal{K}| \cong |\mathcal{L}|$ are homeomorphic, are they combinatorially equivalent. This is true for $\dim \leq 3$.

6.5 Piecewise Linear Maps

Definition 6.5.1 (Piecewise Linear Maps in General)

Let X, Y be spaces. Let $f : X \rightarrow Y$ be a function. We say that f is piecewise linear if there exists locally finite triangulations of X and Y such that f restricted to each simplex is affine linear.

Lemma 6.5.2

Let S, T be simplicial complexes. Let $f : V(S) \rightarrow V(T)$ be a simplicial map. Then $|f| : |S| \rightarrow |T|$ is piecewise linear.

Proposition 6.5.3

Let S, T be simplicial complexes. Let $f : |S| \rightarrow |T|$ be a function. Then f is piecewise linear if and only if there exists subdivisions S' of S and T' of T such that $f : |S'| \rightarrow |T'|$ is simplicial.

Definition 6.5.4 (PL Homeomorphism)

Let X, Y be spaces. Let $f : X \rightarrow Y$ be a piecewise linear function. We say that f is a PL homeomorphism if there exists a piecewise linear function $g : Y \rightarrow X$ such that

$$g \circ f = \text{id}_X \quad \text{and} \quad f \circ g = \text{id}_Y$$

6.6 Combinatorial and Simplicial Spheres

Definition 6.6.1 (Simplicial Spheres)

Let S be a simplicial complex. We say that S is a simplicial sphere if $|S|$ is homeomorphic to a sphere.

Definition 6.6.2 (Combinatorial Spheres)

Let S be a simplicial complex. We say that S is a combinatorial sphere if S is a simplicial sphere and there exists $n \in \mathbb{N}^+$ such that

$$\text{lk}(\sigma) \cong_{\text{PL}} \partial \Delta^{n-|\sigma|+1}$$

for all $\emptyset \neq \sigma \in \mathcal{K}$.

Proposition 6.6.3

Let S be a simplicial complex of dimension 3. Then S is a simplicial sphere if and only if S is a combinatorial sphere.

For $\dim = 4$ this is an open question, for $\dim \geq 5$ the inclusion is strict.

7 Delta Complexes and Simplicial Homology

7.1 Delta Complexes

Definition 7.1.1 (Δ -Complexes)

A Δ -complex $(S_\bullet, d_\bullet)$ consists of the following data.

- For each $n \in \mathbb{N}$, a set S_n of n -simplices.
- For each $n \in \mathbb{N}$ and $0 \leq i \leq n$, a map $d_i^n : S_n \rightarrow S_{n-1}$ such that

$$d_i^{n-1} \circ d_j^n = d_{j-1}^{n-1} \circ d_i^n$$

called the face relation is satisfied whenever $i < j$.

In particular, d_i sends an n -simplex to its i th face, which is an $n - 1$ simplex. This means that for $s = [v_1, \dots, v_n] \in S_n$, $d_i(s) = [v_1, \dots, \hat{v}_i, \dots, v_n]$.

Proposition 7.1.2 Every simplicial complex is a Δ -complex.

Definition 7.1.3 (Geometric Realization of Δ -Complexes)

Let $S = (S_\bullet, d_\bullet)$ be a Δ -set. The geometric realization of S is a topological space X that is built up inductively as follows:

- The 0-skeleton X^0 is a discrete set with points in S_0
- Given the $n - 1$ skeleton X^{n-1} and S_{n-1} . Now define

$$X^n = \left(X^{n-1} \cup \coprod_{\alpha \in I_n} \Delta_\alpha^n \right) / \sim$$

where $\sim$ is the equivalence relation $\Delta_\beta^{n-1} \sim \partial_k \Delta_\alpha^n$ given from the face maps $d_\bullet$. (Intuitively, each face of the n -simplex in S_n gets identified with a $n - 1$ simplex in X^{n-1})

- Define $X = \bigcup_n X^n$. The minimal n for which $X = X^n$ is called the dimension of n

We also write X as $|S|$ to indicate the Δ -set.

Definition 7.1.4 (Map of Delta-Complexes)

Let $S = (S_\bullet, d_\bullet)$ and $S' = (S'_\bullet, d'_\bullet)$ be two Δ -sets. A map of Δ -sets $f : S \rightarrow S'$ is a family of maps $f_n : S_n \rightarrow S'_n$ for each $n \in \mathbb{N}$ such that for all $0 \leq i \leq n$, we have that

$$d'_i \circ f_n = f_{n-1} \circ d_i : S_n \rightarrow S'_{n-1}$$

7.2 Delta Complex Structures

Δ -complexes act much nicer than CW complex because they are combinatorial. Indeed the attaching maps d_j^n given by the Δ -set are combinatorial in nature: we just need to define which element in S_{n-1} each face of the simplex gets mapped to. In other words, $d_k^n : S_n \rightarrow S_{n-1}$ maps each $\Delta \in S_n$ to its k th face in S_{n-1} .

Theorem 7.2.1 The geometric realization of a Δ -complex is a CW complex

However, most of the topological spaces are CW complexes rather than Δ -complexes. Indeed the notion of CW complexes are less restrictive on the attaching maps, while that of Δ -complexes are predetermined the face maps: one has to glue them so that each face of the n -simplexes is identified as an $n - 1$ simplex in the existing skeleton.

Definition 7.2.2 (Delta-complex Structure) Let X be a topological space. A Δ -complex structure on X is a Δ -complex S together with a homeomorphism $|S| \cong X$.

The Δ -complex structure is not unique. For example, one can have multiple ways of even defining a circle, depending the number of points.

7.3 Simplicial Homology

The main goal is now to associate to every Δ -complex an abelian group. This abelian group will serve as an invariant of the Δ -complex. This is a two step process. To every Δ -complex S , we associate a chain complex and then a collection of homology groups

$$S \mapsto (\Delta_\bullet(S), \partial_\bullet) \mapsto H_\bullet(S)$$

with both steps being functorial in the sense that it respects associativity and identity when given a map of Δ -complexes.

We begin by treating the case of Δ -sets.

Definition 7.3.1 (Simplicial n -Chains)

Let $S = (S_\bullet, d_\bullet)$ be a Δ -set. Define the group of simplicial n -chains on S to be the free group

$$C_n^\Delta(S) = \mathbb{Z}\langle \Delta_k^n \mid \Delta_k^n \in S_n \rangle$$

generated by the set of n -simplexes.

All the simplicial n -chains are related by a formula called the boundary operator.

Definition 7.3.2 (Boundary Operator)

Let S be a Δ -set. Define the boundary operator $\partial_n : C_n^\Delta(S) \rightarrow C_{n-1}^\Delta(S)$ by

$$\partial_n(s) = \sum_{k=0}^n (-1)^k d_i^n(s)$$

Proposition 7.3.3

Let S be a Δ -set. Then we have $\partial_{n-1} \circ \partial_n$.

Proof

Let $s \in \Delta_{n+1}(X)$. Then we have that

$$(\partial_n \circ \partial_{n+1})(s) = \partial_n \left(\sum_{j=0}^{n+1} (-1)^j d_j^{n+1}(s) \right) = \sum_{i=0}^n \sum_{j=0}^{n+1} (-1)^{i+j} d_i^n(d_j^{n+1}(s))$$

Fix a pair $0 \leq i < j \leq n+1$. By definition 2.1.5, $A = (-1)^{i+j} d_i^n(d_j^{n+1}(s))$ and $B = (-1)^{i+j} d_{j-1}^n(d_i^{n+1}(s))$ cancel out. Moreover every summand is of the form A or B and not both so that the sum vanishes. In other words, we have that

$$\begin{aligned} \sum_{i=0}^n \sum_{j=0}^{n+1} (-1)^{i+j} d_i^n(d_j^{n+1}(s)) &= \sum_{0 \leq i < j \leq n+1} (-1)^{i+j} d_i^n(d_j^{n+1}(s)) + \sum_{0 \leq j < i \leq n} (-1)^{i+j} d_i^n(d_j^{n+1}(s)) \\ &= \sum_{0 \leq i < j \leq n+1} (-1)^{i+j} d_{j-1}^n(d_i^{n+1}(s)) + \sum_{0 \leq j < i \leq n} (-1)^{i+j} d_i^n(d_j^{n+1}(s)) \\ &= \sum_{0 \leq i \leq j \leq n} (-1)^{i+j-1} d_j^n(d_i^{n+1}(s)) + \sum_{0 \leq j \leq i \leq n} (-1)^{i+j} d_i^n(d_j^{n+1}(s)) \\ &= 0 \end{aligned}$$

We conclude that $(\Delta_\bullet(S), \partial_\bullet)$ forms a chain complex. ■

Definition 7.3.4 (The Induced Map)

Let S, T be Δ -sets. Let $f : S \rightarrow T$ be a map of δ -sets. Define the induced map

$$C_n^\Delta(f) : C_n^\Delta(S) \rightarrow C_n^\Delta(T)$$

by $s \mapsto f_n(s)$.

Definition 7.3.5 (The Simplicial Homology Groups) Let S be a Δ -set and $(\Delta_\bullet(S), \partial_\bullet)$ the chain complex of S .

- Define the group of n -cycles to be $Z_n(S) = \ker(\partial_n)$
- Define the group of n -boundaries to be $B_n(S) = \text{im}(\partial_{n+1})$
- Define the n th simplicial homology group to be the quotient

$$H_n^\Delta(S) = \frac{Z_n(S)}{B_n(S)} = \frac{\ker(\partial_n)}{\text{im}(\partial_{n+1})} = H_n(\Delta_\bullet(S))$$

We have seen that a map between two chain complexes induces a map between the homology groups. We can now define a map between two Δ -sets so that they induce a map in chain complexes and in turn, a map in simplicial homology groups.

Combining with the induced map in homology, we thus have that given a map of Δ -sets, it induces a map in homology.

7.4 Relation to Refinements

Definition 7.4.1 (Induced map of Refinements)

Let $\mathcal{K}, \mathcal{L}$ be simplicial complexes. Suppose that $\mathcal{L}$ is a refinement of $\mathcal{K}$. Define the induced map of chain complexes

$$C_n^\Delta(\mathcal{K}) \rightarrow C_n^\Delta(\mathcal{L})$$

by $\sigma \mapsto \sum_{\tau \in \mathcal{L}, \tau \subseteq \sigma} (-1)^{k_\tau} \tau$

Composing with the induced map $C_n^\Delta(\mathcal{L}) \rightarrow C_n^\Delta(\mathcal{K})$ induced isomorphisms on homology.

7.5 Simplicial Cohomology

7.6 The Alexander Dual

Definition 7.6.1 (The Alexander Dual)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. Suppose that $\mathcal{K} \neq \Delta^{n-1}$. Define the Alexander dual of $\mathcal{K}$ to be

$$\widehat{\mathcal{K}} = \{I \subseteq \{1, \dots, n\} \mid \{1, \dots, n\} \setminus I \notin \mathcal{K}\}$$

Lemma 7.6.2

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. Suppose that $\mathcal{K} \neq \Delta^{n-1}$. Then we have $\widehat{\widehat{\mathcal{K}}} = \mathcal{K}$.

Lemma 7.6.3

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. Let $\sigma \in \mathcal{K}$. Then σ is a facet of $\widehat{\mathcal{K}}$ if and only if $\{1, \dots, n\} \setminus \sigma \in \text{MF}(\mathcal{K})$.

Theorem 7.6.4 (Combinatorial Alexander Duality)

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. Suppose that $\mathcal{K} \neq \Delta^{n-1}$. Then there is an isomorphism

$$\widetilde{H}^j(\mathcal{K}) = \widetilde{H}_{n-3-j}(\widehat{\mathcal{K}})$$

for $-1 \leq j \leq n-2$ where we set $\widetilde{H}^{-1}(\mathcal{K}) = \mathbb{Z}$.

Corollary 7.6.5

Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a simplicial complex on $\{1, \dots, n\}$. Suppose that $\mathcal{K} \neq \Delta^{n-1}$. Let $I \subseteq \{1, \dots, n\}$ such that

$I \notin \mathcal{K}$. Then there is an isomorphism

$$\tilde{H}^j(\mathcal{K}_I) = \tilde{H}_{n-3-j}(\mathrm{lk}_{\hat{\mathcal{K}}}(\{1, \dots, n\} \setminus I))$$

for $-1 \leq j \leq |I| - 2$.